2026
FSI Veterans Hackathon

Six AI challenges. One fun day. A veteran at the heart of every build.

Microsoft Garage, New York City · Thursday, November 5, 2026
8:00 AM – 6:00 PM · 4–6 teams, mixed across all three firms

No pre-work. No homework. No hacker badge required.
Coders, designers, storytellers and veterans all welcome. Bring your personal laptop and your favorite AI tools.

CO-HOSTS

Microsoft
BlackRock
BNY

SUPPORTING NONPROFITS

Bob Woodruff Foundation
Cloud Veterans

Use any AI tools you like. An Azure environment is available if your team wants it.

Built on the Bob Woodruff Foundation's 2025 Got Your 6 Community Survey: 210 frontline organizations, 26 needs measured

“No single organization can address the full range of needs; that requires a coordinated network response.”

Bob Woodruff Foundation, Quantifying and Addressing Veterans’ Needs, November 2025

One day. Three firms. Two nonprofits. Six challenges.

Come build something that matters, meet great people from across the industry, and have a blast doing it.

2026 FSI VETERANS HACKATHON

Microsoft Garage, New York City · November 5, 2026 · Co-hosted by Microsoft · BlackRock · BNY With the Bob Woodruff Foundation and Cloud Veterans

Why this matters

what the data says about the people we are building for

The Bob Woodruff Foundation surveyed 210 frontline organizations that serve veterans and military families. Their message: more veterans need help with the basics, and local communities can't keep up.

73%

say many or almost all of their clients need housing help

Only 20% of communities can fully meet it.

75%

say many or almost all of their clients need emergency money

78% of communities can't fully meet it.

69%

say many or almost all of their clients need help finding work

58% of communities can't fully meet it.

60%

say many or almost all of their clients need money skills help

Up from 41% in 2021. Half of communities can't fully meet it.

WHAT CHANGED SINCE 2023

Share of organizations saying ALMOST ALL of their clients need…

Housing help	**4% → 25%**
Emergency money	**18% → 27%**
Food help	**6% → 18%**
Mental health care	**18% → 29%**
Legal help	**2% → 9%**

WHERE WE COME IN

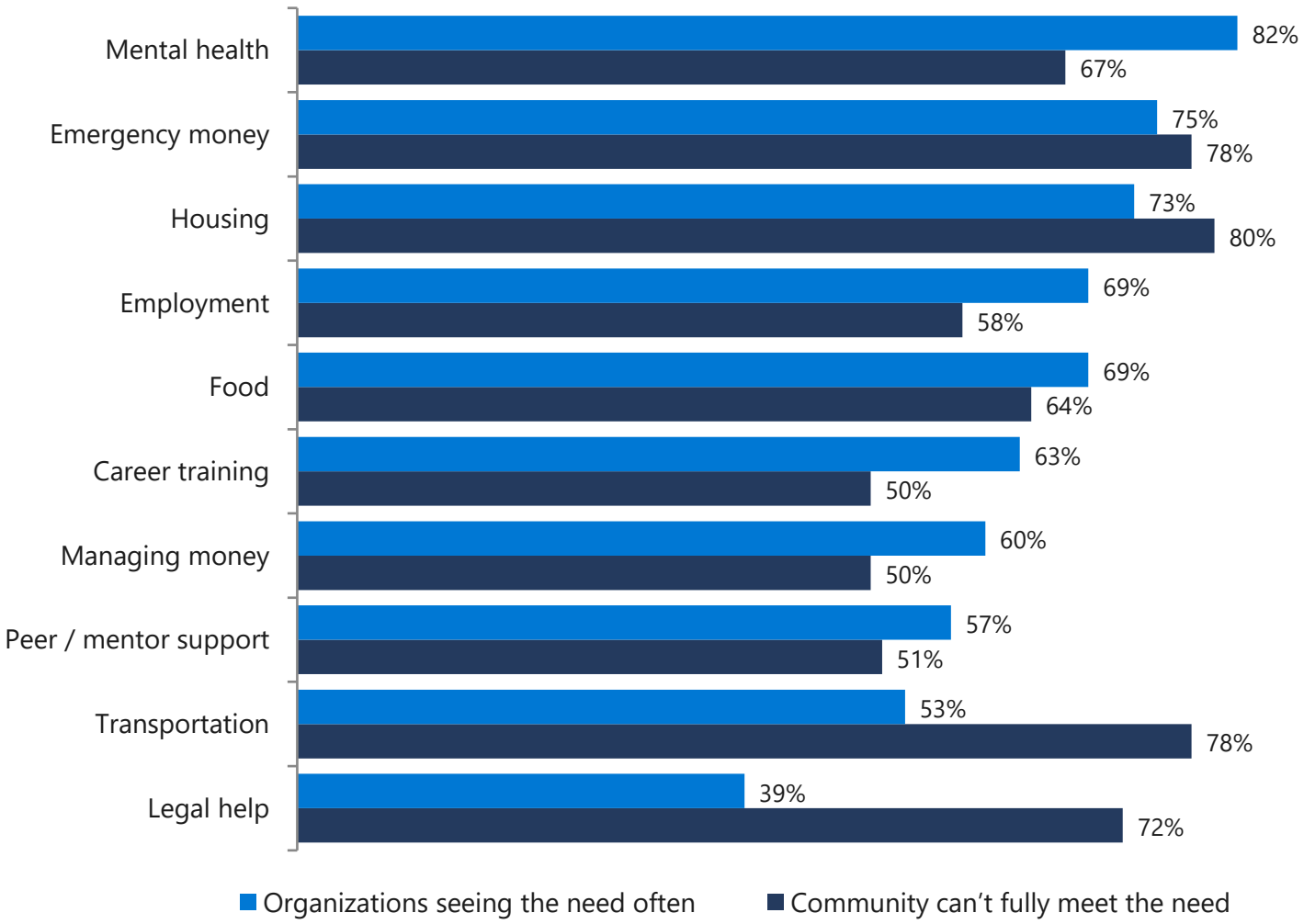
Frontline organizations are working hard and are already at capacity. Things slip through the cracks: the problem nobody asked about, the request for help that never got answered, the veteran who had to tell the same story five times.

That's where a little smart software can help. That's what we're building.

Source: BWF Got Your 6 Community Survey, 2025

Where the gaps are

how often each need shows up, and how often communities fall short



Source: BWF Got Your 6 Community Survey, 2025 (200 organizations). Some values read from the report's charts.

HOW TO READ THIS

Light bar: share of the 200 organizations who say many or almost all of their clients have this need.

Dark bar: share who say their community can't fully meet it.

When the dark bar is longer, demand has outgrown the help available.

THE BLIND SPOT

Legal help is near the bottom of the need list but near the top of the gap list.

BWF suggests the low number may be a missed opportunity: VA studies find legal issues make up most of the unmet needs of homeless veterans.

You don’t have to be a coder

every team needs more than one kind of superpower

Teams are mixed across Microsoft, BlackRock and BNY. Pick a role (or two) that sounds fun. Nobody needs to know anything about veterans’ services in advance; your team’s Starter Kit has everything.



Builder

Builds the tool with whatever AI helpers the team likes, from coding assistants to no-code builders.



Designer

Sketches the screens and keeps every word plain and friendly.



Veteran voice

Veterans and anyone who knows the topic. Keeps the team honest: “would a real veteran use this?”



Tester

Tries to break it, spots confusing steps, and checks the AI isn’t making things up.



Storyteller

Owns the 5-minute demo. Makes the judges care about the veteran in your story.



Every team gets a Starter Kit at 9:05 AM

A made-up veteran to build for, realistic sample documents, three “must-haves” and two bonus options. It’s all made up, so it’s safe to paste into any AI tool. An Azure environment is there if you want it.

The six challenges

each team picks one, and two teams can pick the same one

01 Roof and Runway

Housing and emergency money

Sam describes a housing and money crisis in everyday words and gets up to three programs that may fit, each explained in plain English.

Microsoft · Military at Microsoft

02 Money Moves

Managing money

Chris brings a confusing pay stub or letter and leaves understanding it, with one small money step for this week.

Spun off from Challenge 04

03 Someone Who Has Been There

Peer support and loneliness

Two veterans' stories go in. A match comes out, with a reason a real person would nod at.

Microsoft · Military at Microsoft

04 Veterans Build America

Jobs and career training

Jordan's military record goes in. Out come the skills that carry over, what's still missing, and one action for this week.

Contributed by BlackRock

05 The Last Mile

Legal help, transportation and food

A case worker's note goes in. The urgent problem that was only mentioned in passing comes out, with its deadline.

Microsoft · Military at Microsoft

06 Veteran Stability Navigator

Telling your story once

Alex tells their story once, approves a short summary, and picks the right first place to go.

Contributed by BlackRock

01 Roof and Runway

from "apply to everything" to "here's where to start"

THE CHALLENGE

Sam describes their situation in everyday words. Your tool suggests up to three help programs that might fit, explains why in plain English, and helps Sam get started.

Meet Sam Rivera (made up). *Sam's work hours were cut eleven weeks ago. Rent is 60 days behind, there's an eviction notice on the door, and three different organizations have told Sam to "apply to everything."*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Sam types (or says) what's going on in their own words. No long form to fill in.
2. The tool shows up to three programs that may fit, each with the line from the fact sheet that explains why.
3. If something is unclear, the tool asks Sam one simple question instead of guessing.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Draft a short application in Sam's own words that Sam can edit.
Option B: Show one program Sam doesn't qualify for, and why.

WHY IT MATTERS

73%	of organizations say many or almost all clients need housing help
20%	of communities can fully meet that need
4% → 25%	say ALMOST ALL clients need housing help (2023 to 2025)

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

Six short, made-up program fact sheets: who qualifies, how much each pays and how fast. Real ones are long, confusing and sometimes contradict each other, so ours are a little messy too. Your AI reads them so Sam doesn't have to.

Where AI shines: Reading messy rules and explaining them in plain English.
Ground rule: The tool suggests; people decide. It never approves or denies anyone.

02

Money Moves

making money stuff make sense

MANAGING MONEY

Spun off from Challenge 04

THE CHALLENGE

Help a veteran make sense of a confusing money moment, like a first civilian paycheck or a collections letter, and leave with one small step they can take this week.

Meet Chris Ortiz (made up). *Chris left the Army three months ago. The first civilian paycheck was smaller than expected, a letter from a collections agency just arrived, and Chris isn't sure what to tackle first.*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Chris pastes in a document from the kit or describes the problem in their own words.
2. The tool explains it in plain language: no jargon, no judgment.
3. Chris gets one small, doable step for this week, plus where to find a real person for anything bigger.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Add a simple "what if?" (What if I set aside $50 a month?).
Option B: Turn the step into a reminder Chris can keep.

WHY IT MATTERS

60% say many or almost all clients need help managing money

41% → 60% how that share has grown, 2021 to 2025

Half of communities can't fully meet the need

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

Text versions of a military pay statement and a civilian pay stub, a sample collections letter, a simple monthly budget, and a short list of made-up free help options (like a credit counselor).

Where AI shines: Turning confusing paperwork into plain talk.

Ground rule: Explains and educates only. No investment, tax or legal advice.

03 Someone Who Has Been There

matching on life experience, not checkboxes

THE CHALLENGE

Read veterans' stories in their own words and explain, in plain language, why two of them would understand each other. Then help them say hello.

Meet Marcus Hale (made up). *Nineteen years in, fourteen months out. Marcus has turned down three group programs and doesn't want a counselor. He wants someone who already knows what he's about to say.*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Marcus tells his story in his own words, not by picking from dropdown menus.
2. The tool suggests two possible mentors (no scores) and explains what they share and where they differ.
3. Marcus chooses exactly what the mentor gets to see before anything is shared.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Draft a friendly first message the mentor can edit.
Option B: Find the "unlikely but right" match hidden in the kit.

WHY IT MATTERS

57% say many or almost all clients need a peer or mentor

51% of communities can't fully meet that need

62% see a significant need for basic social connection

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

Six short, made-up veteran stories written the way people really talk, including one pair that looks perfect on paper but wouldn't click, and one unlikely pair that would.

Where AI shines: Understanding stories, not just matching keywords.

Ground rule: Mentors are peers, not counselors. Always show where to get professional help (Veterans Crisis Line: 988, press 1).

04

Veterans Build America

from military experience to a real next step

JOBS AND CAREER TRAINING

Contributed by BlackRock

THE CHALLENGE

Help a veteran see which military skills carry over to a civilian career, what's still missing, and one step to take this week.

Meet Jordan Lee (made up). *Jordan is leaving the service with years of equipment maintenance and troubleshooting experience, and wants a hands-on, earn-while-you-learn job in the skilled trades near northern New Jersey.*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Pull skills from Jordan's military record and show the line each one came from.
2. Jordan confirms or fixes the skills list.
3. Compare two career paths: what fits, what's missing, and one action for this week.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Build a one-page plan with the action, a due date and a backup.
Option B: Use the real VA benefits timetable to show which benefits and deadlines apply to Jordan.

WHY IT MATTERS

69% of organizations say many or almost all clients need help finding work

63% say the same about career training

58% of communities can't fully meet the employment need

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

A made-up military training record (like a Joint Services Transcript), two sample trade career paths, one sample job opening, and a real VA benefits timetable for the bonus.

Where AI shines: Translating military language into civilian language.

Ground rule: No hiring decisions and no aptitude scores. Jordan stays in control.

05 The Last Mile

finding the problem nobody asked about

THE CHALLENGE

Read an ordinary case worker's note, spot the urgent problem that was only mentioned in passing (like a court date), and help the case worker act before time runs out.

Meet Ruth Calloway (made up). *Ruth lives in a rural county with no car and came in for a food box. Buried in her case note: an eviction hearing in eleven days, and a suspended driver's license she mentioned once.*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Read a note and list the problems found, each with the sentence it came from.
2. Put them on a simple timeline: what's due first.
3. The case worker confirms the list before anything else happens.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Draft a request for help to the legal clinic that the case worker can edit.
Option B: Show a backup option if the first service is full.

WHY IT MATTERS

39% of organizations see a big need for legal help

72% say their community can't fully meet it: a blind spot

78% of communities can't fully meet the need for transportation

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

Four made-up case worker notes (one with a court date buried in it, one where having no car blocks everything) and three made-up local services: a legal aid clinic, a ride program and a food pantry.

Where AI shines: Spotting what a busy person might miss.
Ground rule: No legal advice. The tool points things out; people decide.

06

Veteran Stability Navigator

tell your story once, not five times

THE CHALLENGE

Alex shouldn't have to repeat the same hard story to every organization. Build a tool where Alex tells it once, gets a short summary, picks the right first place to go, and decides exactly what gets shared.

Meet Alex Morgan (made up). *Alex recently lost a job, is behind on rent and has limited transportation. Alex is tired of repeating the same personal details to one organization after another.*

MUST-HAVES · build these three and you have a great demo

1. Alex describes what's going on; the tool writes a short summary Alex can edit.
2. The tool suggests one main organization and one backup, and explains why.
3. Alex ticks exactly which details get shared before anything is sent.

Bonus round: two options, pick one (only if you have time)
Option A: Gently ask about a need Alex didn't mention (Alex can say no thanks).
Option B: Show a status: sent, received, follow-up due.

WHY IT MATTERS

75% of organizations say many or almost all clients need emergency money

78% of communities can't fully meet that need

69% say many or almost all clients need help with food

IN YOUR STARTER KIT

One made-up veteran profile and four made-up local organizations with their services, location, hours and how to reach them. Your tool picks a main choice and a backup.

Where AI shines: Turning a messy story into a clear summary, in Alex's own words.

Ground rule: Nothing is shared without Alex's OK. No scoring or ranking of people.

Words you'll hear today

a quick cheat sheet, so nobody feels lost

GLOSSARY

AI model	The "brain" your tool uses to read, write and reason, like the one behind Copilot or ChatGPT.
Starter Kit	Your team's packet: a made-up veteran, sample documents and your challenge's must-haves.
Demo	A 5-minute live show-and-tell of what your team built.
Case worker	The person at a nonprofit who helps a veteran find services. Sometimes called a navigator.
Consent	The veteran saying "yes, you may share this." Nothing is shared without it.
Joint Services Transcript	An official record of a service member's military training and jobs, often used to show skills to schools and employers.
Made-up (synthetic) data	Realistic but fictional people and documents. No real personal information is used, ever.
Azure	Microsoft's cloud. An optional Azure environment is provided for teams that want to use it.
Code folder ("repo")	A shared online folder where each team saves its code before demos.
Referral	A request from one organization to another: "Can you help this veteran?"
Qualifying (eligibility)	Whether someone meets a program's rules, like income, location or service history.
Got Your 6	Military slang for "I've got your back." Also the name of BWF's network of frontline organizations.

The day at a glance

8:00 AM to 6:00 PM · six hours of building, a real lunch, and room to breathe

8:00 AM	45 min	Doors open: breakfast, name badges, meet your team
8:45 AM	20 min	Welcome: share why this matters
9:05 AM	25 min	Team and challenge lock in, grab your Starter Kit, Azure access if you want it
9:30 AM	2 hr	**BUILD BLOCK 1**
11:30 AM	45 min	Lunch: a real break. Sit with someone from another firm.
12:15 PM	2 hr 30 min	**BUILD BLOCK 2**
2:45 PM	15 min	Stretch and an optional “sneak peek swap”
3:00 PM	1 hr 45 mins	**BUILD BLOCK 3: the final sprint**
4:45 PM	15 min	Pencils down: save your code, set up your demo
5:00 PM	45 min	**DEMOS: 5 minutes to show + 2 minutes of questions per team**
5:45 PM	15 min	Judges huddle and team photos
6:00 PM	1 hr	Awards, wrap-up, networking
7:00 PM	0 mins	Close up shop. See you next year!

HELP IS ALWAYS NEARBY

Tech mentors: Azure and AI experts walking the floor during every build block.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF THE DAY

“Demo one veteran, one need, and one moment where AI does something a spreadsheet couldn’t.”

Finish your three must-haves first. Then, if there’s time, pick one bonus option.

Suggested team check-ins

optional, quick and just for your team: nobody is grading these

9:45 AM



Huddle

Pick roles. Agree on the one moment you'll demo. Who is your veteran and what do they need?

11:15 AM



Sketch check

Can you walk through your three must-haves on a whiteboard before lunch?

1:30 PM



Click-through

Can you click from start to finish, even if some parts are still fake?

2:45 PM



Sneak peek swap

Optional: show another team in 3 minutes. Trade one tip each.

4:00 PM



Feature freeze

Stop adding things. Fix what's broken. Rehearse your demo twice.



Pro tip: the teams that win usually aren't the ones with the most features. They're the ones with the clearest story about one veteran.

Rules, judging and prizes

short and simple

HOUSE RULES

Mix it up	Each team can include a mix people from Cloud Veterans, Microsoft, BlackRock and BNY.
Let the AI do real work	Judges will ask what the AI is actually doing. A chat window added on top won't place.
Your laptop, your tools	Use a personal laptop and personal accounts, not work ones. Any AI tools are welcome; Azure is optional.
Made-up data only	No real personal information, ever. It's all in your Starter Kit.
Save before you show	Put your code in the shared hackathon folder before pencils down at 4:30 PM.

HOW JUDGES SCORE

30%	**Tackles a real gap** Does it go after a need from the BWF survey?
25%	**Veteran-first and respectful** Plain language, asks only what it needs, the veteran stays in control.
25%	**Smart use of AI** Does it do something a spreadsheet couldn't? Is it honest about what it doesn't know?
20%	**The demo** A clear story that works live, about a veteran we come to care about.

PRIZES

- **Best Overall**
- **Most Ambitious**
- **Most Creative Idea**

See you at the Garage

Microsoft Garage, New York City · Thursday, November 5, 2026 · Doors open 8:00 AM

Bring

Your personal laptop (not your work one), a charger, and your favorite AI tools signed in and ready.

Skip

Pre-work, homework and any worry about being “technical enough.”

Expect

Good food, new friends from three firms, veterans in the room, and something real to show by 5 PM.

Co-hosted by Microsoft · BlackRock · BNY With the Bob Woodruff Foundation and Cloud Veterans